would coincide with Baisakhi (April 13) celebrations at the Golden Temple. He could not guess how many civilians might be present at the time. Finally, he said that about 20 per cent of the civilians coming in the way of the operation could also be killed. The PM said she could not afford such a large number of civilian casualties. The operation was killed there and then.

When I asked Nagrani about the selection of Baisakhi day for the operation, he said nobody at that time thought of postponing or bringing forward the date of the operation. Significantly, towards the end of the briefing, Indira Gandhi, in a pensive mood, remarked that she knew that, sooner or later, she would be killed by Sikh extremists, but she was not worried about that. Her main concern was what would happen to her children after her death. [9]

Let us examine the number of casualties that would have resulted from this operation. An Mi4 helicopter can carry between eight to sixteen passengers. Let us assume that two SSF Mi4 helicopters were carrying twelve fully equipped commandos each for the operation. If the casualty rate were 20 per cent, then five of the twenty-four commandos would be lost. Let us also assume that around 300 persons including Bhindranwale's ten guards, constituted his audience on the langar complex rooftop at the time of the operation. The normal reaction of the civilians would be to run for cover or escape on seeing the helicopters approach. Even if we presume that all 300 people came in the way of the operation, the total civilian casualties would amount to sixty persons per the estimate.

As the exit route would already have been sanitized by the CRPF, nobody would have come in the way of the commandos leaving with Bhindranwale from the side road. Both Kao and Nagrani were very cautious in projecting such estimates and would not have made tall claims or promised what they could not deliver. Given their propensity to err on the side of caution, even the estimates of expected casualties shared by Nagrani with the prime minister at the special briefing would have been on the higher side. Contrast the estimated losses from this operation with the horrific loss of life and the scale of destruction eventually caused by Operation Blue Star.